31.03.2026

One day, after making this journey, she had arrived at her street - the Paraya street - she saw that the Naickers had set up a platform to watch the proceedings of the Parayas driving cattle in pairs to separate the grain from the straw. It was at this time that an elder came along from the bazaar holding a package by its string. This made Bama want to laugh; the sight of a big man holding the snacks by its string as though the package would come undone at any moment and its contents would fall off. He walked straight up to the Naicker, bowed and offered the package by the string as the Naicker opened the package and ate his vadais. After she got home Bama explained the entire thing to her older brother in excessive, comic detail. Although she was falling out of laughter, her brother was not amused. He explained that he was not doing what he did to be funny but rather because he was a Paraya - a lower caste and an upper caste man like the Naicker could not touch the things a man from the lower caste touched as it could "pollute" them.

Knowing this infuriated Bama. She didn't understand why the respected elders of her caste had to fetch and carry for these people from the so-called "upper" castes. She was so enraged that she wanted to go and touch those vadais herself. She started doubting if the word "Paraya" was an obscenity as the people of her caste are considered disgusting.

She narrates the experience of how both her grandmothers. servants for the Naicker households were treated inferiorly and ordered around by even small children just because they were Naicker. The way her grandmother was given water was pitiful as well. The Naicker women would pour water from the height of four feet and her grandmother would drink it with cupped hands. Her other grandmother would go to the Naicker house, do all the chores, and then bring back unwanted food.

Once when Bama accompanied her grandmother to work in a Naicker household, her grandmother kept her vessel next to a drain where a Naicker woman came and tipped her leftovers in. This enraged young Bama who asked her Paatti (grandmother) to not put up with such demeaning behaviour. Her grandmother in turn asked her if they didn't maintain the status quo then who would feed the family and that this has been the way it has been for generations. The upper castes remain the upper castes and the lower ones remain that way as well.

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One such day, Bama's brother had returned from college for vacation and went to a library in the neighbourhood village to borrow books. Upon returning, he was intercepted by someone from the Naicker caste who asked for his name and caste. Upon learning that he was a Paraya from the Cheri street, he was infuriated with the way he was spoken to. Although her brother stalked off hurriedly, the Naicker man had asked around about him and someone had informed him that he was the grandson of the Paraya lady working at their house. The next day, her paatti received scolding from the Naicker and Paatti managed to handle it by citing his education as the reason for his behaviour. Even at the library her brother was given no respect or value at all when they came to know that he was a Paraya; however, when he signed "MA" with his name, they gave him ample respect. This is why Bama was asked to pay her education full importance by her brother as it is the only way to break the shackles of the caste. When people learn that you're well educated they automatically give you due respect and dignity. In due time, Bama learned that this is true when she herself came out at the top of her class and more people than usual wanted to be friends with her.

However, in school, everything that went wrong was blamed upon the people of her caste. Yet they did not hesitate to use these children for menial chores like carrying water or watering the plants.

Once while playing in the school yard, they came up with a game of touching the coconuts on the coconut tree. This was entirely possible as the coconut tree was extremely bent at a convenient angle. In the excitement of their game, some would even twist and tug at the coconut before they climbed down the tree. And so, when it was Bama's turn, the unripe green coconut came off in her hands and fell with a thud. Everybody scattered and word got around that she had plucked the coconut. The next day at the school assembly the headmaster called Bama out by her name and berated her by insulting her caste. She was forbidden from entering the school. Extremely humiliated, she stood there as a teacher from the same street as her walked by and advised her to go to the priest and get a note allowing her to enter the school. The priest upon hearing the story endorsed the headmaster's view and wrote her a note after she wept for a long time. When she went to the headmaster with the note, he scolded her and used swear words when berating her and let her go to class where everyone looked at her as she drowned in mortification.

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Bama attended high school in another village, where everyone.... dressed well and looked smart and the campus was big and well built as well. It took her some getting used to before she could feel she was a part of the school. This was easier as she immersed herself in her studies eagerly.

In the hostel, the warden was completely discriminatory towards the hostelers based on their caste. All the Paraya children were often scolded everyday for no reason at all. Sometimes, the fat children were scolded because they grew fat after eating from the hostel more than their homes.

When she returned home from school, if a Naicker woman sat next to her on the bus the conversation would always be steered toward the caste and the street. When they learned that she was from Cheri, they would get up and move away or ask her to move away. But she never conceded. They would rather prefer to stand all the way home than sit next to a Paraya person. And though her mother advised her to lie about her caste, Bama could never understand the point in it as she believed that she should not have to lie about it in the first place.

Bama was excellent in her classes and this won her lots of respect and admiration from teachers and fellow students alike. She would often be asked to help other students who didn't do as well as her in their lessons and this only encouraged her to excel even further. However, sometimes the teachers would ask all Harijan students to stand up as they jotted down their names. This was an extremely humiliating exercise as it made the students feel like they did something worth being guilty for.

In the SSLC examination, Bama scored the most marks in her class and won a prize as the first Harijan student to ever achieve this feat. She was applauded and awarded for her achievement as she felt pride instead of shame about her caste.

After Bama finished her schooling, she went to a college in a village a bit farther away. Here, she thought that she would have no trouble with the people from upper castes and that no one would bother with things like caste. She was wrong. One day, the lecturer asks all the Harijan students to stand up as the government has arranged for extra tuition classes for students from the Scheduled Castes. As Bama and another girl stood up, there was a shuffle of contempt in the class. This

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infuriated young Bama who claimed that she didn't need those classes and sat back down.

Similarly, once when she had asked for permission to leave for home on the weekend as it was her siblings' First Communion, the headmaster and the warden collectively denied her permission even though they were visibly allowing all the wealthy kids from upper castes to go home. They made a snide comment about how they won't have much of a celebration in her caste, which infuriated her. She stood her ground and stayed stubborn which resulted in them allowing her to go eventually.

She joined a different college for a B.Ed degree and encountered the same issues more or less. But everywhere she went she realised things were much better for her since she was a great student. Everyone showed her a certain amount of respect which made her realise that education is the only way to break the shackles of casteism.

She worked in a school for five years where she faced all kinds of oppression from nuns who worked there. She also saw that most of her students were dalits who were also discriminated against on the basis of caste. This made her want to bring a change from within the organisation. The thought of becoming a nun and changing the system from within kept recurring until one day she decided to give into that pull. She resigned her post as a teacher and joined Christian religious order. Despite objections from friends and family, she adamantly became a nun as she wanted to help the poor and the downtrodden like the woman who founded the particular convent that she joined. However, upon joining she found out that it was starkly different from her expectations and goals. Although she was deeply troubled, she thought she would give it the benefit of doubt.

Sooner than later she realised that being in the convent was to be doubly-marginalized, first for being a Tamil and second for being a Paraya within the Tamil community. Once, a Sister who was supervising their training had called Bama and asked her why the birth dates were different on the birth certificate and the degree certificate. Bama tried explaining how the people at her school would put down whatever birth date they chose for the students as it did not matter very much because of the informal atmosphere of the village life and yet, the Sister

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would not listen. Instead, she chose to humiliate her by insulting her Tamilian origins.

Soon she found out that in the convent, Tamil people were looked down upon as a whole and that within the Tamilians, the Parayas were looked down upon as a lower caste. In short, Bama was experiencing double marginalisation within the order.

Towards the end of their training, a Sister had mentioned that Harijan women might not be accepted in certain orders and there are some separate orders for them. A worried, despairing Bama went to her and explained that she was a Harijan woman. Although the Sister assured her that she would be accepted into orders, Bama was still extremely disappointed in the fact that the threads of caste politics were woven into every face and facet of life.

The convent and the school that Bama was sent to were an extremely casteist, elitist institution. In this place, the Harijan community did all the dirty, menial work around the premises - cleaning, sweeping, and washing - as all the wealthy students attended classes. Even within the convent, the lower caste was spoken of in a very demeaning manner and although Bama wanted to snap at them by laying bare her identity, she chose to keep quiet and not let them know.

Bama talks about the way caste discrimination affects the lives of people until their death. This discrimination and persistent degradation from the outside world is why people from the lower caste will never be able to progress like everyone else. Systematic alienation affects every part of one's life and there can only be so much fight in one person. The struggle follows you everywhere you go, there is no respite from it.

The possession of capital social and fiscal - is how the upper castes stay where they are. They persistently rob this capital from a lower social stratum, to keep it that way. They are considered too gross to touch, too gross to look at and too gross to speak to even though they are in essence just as human. Constant dehumanisation through generations and centuries has caused the Dalits to internalise this hatred. This leads to a sort of self victimisation that is hard to come out of. Even if one does manage to recognise it and work through it, they are faced with troubles from within and outside their community.

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Chapter 3

When Bama was eleven years old, her mother gave birth to twins. Although this was meant to be delightful news, the older people got anxious at the thought of having to raise twins in this community as they were constantly in rift with the Chaaliyar community.

The Christian cemetery was located next to the Chaaliyar community school. Only the Dalits buried their dead there. The fights had started because the Chaaliyar community claimed that the cemetery actually belonged to them. They wanted to turn it into a playground or a garden.

Even though they had no courage or bravery, they had land and property which gave them an upper hand over the Parayas. However, they kept picking fights even though they kept losing to the Dalit boys.

Children who usually had to cross the Chaaliyar settlement on their way to school were forbidden by the elders from doing so. Women and children were advised to not go out alone and men were asked to carry a weapon in their possession at all times. Even so, an incident had occurred on the street where Izhava's husband was stabbed by Chaaliyar boys. Utter chaos ensued as women wailed and people ran amok in the streets with worry and fear. Bama had only come back from school and everyone was asked to not go outdoors.

Men, women, children and even the street dogs ran towards the cemetery with knives and staffs. The entire street was desolate as everyone emptied into the cemetery gardens where fights ensued. Chaaliyaar women hid behind the trees and flung stones and rocks. Chaaliyar men ran past the Paraya men into the school building and locked the doors. This cowardice infuriated the Paraya people even more. After this, things gradually returned to normal in the street. For a few days, it was quiet and calm. But fights broke out again as few of the Paraya people had beaten up a Chaaliyar fellow. The Chaaliyar went and filed a case against them with the police. They fabricated a case and framed all of the Paraya people for vandalising Chaaliyar property. The older men made decisions to make bombs and gather weapons and get ready for war. Sadly, Bama couldn't witness the ordeal as her parents locked her in the house in fear of her safety. Around the same time, her siblings - the twins - fell ill and her grandmother and mother had to carry each of

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them to the hospital which was two miles away. Bama was appointed the responsibility of looking after the house and her sister who was seven years old.

Without delay there was uproar in the street as men and women ran towards the cemetery fully prepared for battle. Bama really wanted to follow them. In order to arrive at the cemetery, one had to cross about five streets towards the very edge of the village where there was a fig tree. Bama knew this as she had been there, fruit picking, before.

Bama, against her better judgement, left her sister in charge of the house and rushed towards the cemetery. As she arrived, she witnessed that her people were standing on their side of the street flinging stones. They moved forward throwing rocks, carrying sticks and poles as the women and children followed. Not a child was to be seen from the Chaaliyar side. Kids of Bama's age as well as Bama were sure that they had defeated the Chaaliyar people who had run away and hidden.

As they rejoiced, things took a tragic turn real fast as a huge gang of policemen came out from the shadows with batons in their hands, mercilessly beating up anyone they could get hold of as the Paraya people ran. Everyone fled as the police chased them and caught as many people as they could. The policemen then came into the village into their streets and started beating up anyone who was seen at the cemetery. Many of the Paraya men ran as far away into the mountains and the woods as possible and escaped.

The women watched helplessly from their houses as the men were being beaten up black and blue by their husbands. As Bama's mother and grandmother approached, they asked her about everything that transpired. She told them everything in detail. She got a scolding for having gone to the cemetery but they left it at that as everyone was anxious and the streets had gone gravely silent. After a while, her grandmother returned from outside and told them that the Chaaliyar people had brought over people known as the 'Reserve Police' to destroy the Paraya men. They were being fed feasts by slaughtering sheep. She lamented about how the government or the police will never be on their side as they are poor and have a hard time finding the watery gruel that's on the dinner table. She also added that they have rounded up and arrested every single man that they could find.

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That night no one could sleep as the only sound was the sound of the police boots and barking dogs. They couldn't sleep as they feared that any sound that came out of the house would result in the police coming over into their houses. So they shushed their babies and tried to quieten their fears in vain..

The next day the women went about their work as usual and compensated for the men's work as well. The police continued to roam about trying to round up the men who had escaped previous night. As usual, the women worked in the fields and brought gruel to the men hiding in the woods and updated them on the status in the streets. One day, the policemen began to enter the houses as some Pallar men had tipped them off saying that some men might be hiding inside the houses.

The headman came rushing in and hid himself in the big pot where they stored paddy, followed by his mother who said that policemen were still searching the houses and he couldn't hide anywhere else at that moment. After a while, the police stormed in the house and kicked open every door and looked everywhere. The headman had locked the door from the inside of the room where the storage jar was kept. When the police tried to kick it open they realised that it was locked and demanded that Bama's mother open it. When she tried to do as she was told, it became apparent that the door was bolted from the inside. This raised their suspicions and they kicked it until it opened and found the headman in the jar. They lifted him by the hair and beat him black and blue. They dragged him out of the house as the headman's mother begged them to let go of her son. A couple of houses had succeeded in hiding their men inside them. As they marched in and out of the houses they behaved with the women in an extremely derogatory manner by using disgusting language and saying sexually inappropriate things.

By night time, the terrified women gathered their children and their cattle at the church courtyard. Bama insisted that they go to her mother but didn't know how they would handle infants in a crowded place with no place to hang their cradles.

The next day, the women went about their work as usual which infuriated the policemen. So they rounded all of them up into a lorry and dropped them off on the other side in the village. They were even further enraged when they heard that the working women were actually bringing food to their men hiding in the forest. After a couple of days, someone ratted out the men hiding. in the church beneath the

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